

Stories That Shape Us

Identity, culture, and community through personal narratives

Grade: 7 | **Content:** ELA + ENL

Proficiency: Emerging-Expanding | **Duration:** 60 minutes

ENGLISH + SPANISH EDITION | Paired student materials on pages 5-7. Use these labels, prompts, and frames during the lesson sequence.

Portfolio focus: Personal narrative, identity, culturally responsive instruction, academic discussion, and translanguaging.

Lesson context

Students are beginning a personal narrative unit in a multilingual classroom. Before drafting a longer narrative, they explore how objects, places, languages, traditions, and experiences can carry meaning. This is a sample instructional scenario.

Essential question

How do our experiences and communities shape who we are?

Objectives

Content: Analyze how a short narrative communicates identity and develop a narrative about a meaningful experience, place, object, language, or tradition.

Language: Explain a connection using descriptive details, sequencing words, and a statement of significance.

_____ is important to me because _____.

Although someone else might see _____ as ordinary, it represents _____ to me because _____.

Vocabulary and target language

Concepts: identity, community, tradition, narrative, sensory detail, significance.

Connectors: first, later, when, because, although, this reminds me of, this is important because.

Materials and student choice

Prepare object photographs, an identity-web organizer, the mentor text, annotation tools, a beginning-middle-end planner, a writing checklist, and an exit ticket.

Offer a fictional or imagined narrative option. Students do not have to disclose family experiences, religion, migration history, or private memories. Sharing personal writing is optional.

Connect. Interpret. Create.

1. Identity objects | 5 minutes

Display images such as a book, basketball, headphones, necklace, transit card, food, or photograph. Ask: **How can an object tell a story about a person?** Students discuss a chosen object with a partner.

2. Identity brainstorm | 7 minutes

Create a web with ME at the center. Optional branches: languages, neighborhood, hobbies, traditions, food, music, places, goals, and experiences. Allow words, drawings, or bilingual notes. Students select only what they wish to share.

3. Read and annotate | 10 minutes

Read the teacher-created mentor text aloud, then reread with partners. Ask: What is the object? Why is it important? What does it tell us about the narrator?

Mark meaningful details with a box, emotion words with an underline, and sequencing words with a circle. Use symbols as well as color. Discuss: **The writer shows that ____ matters because ____.**

4. Teacher modeling | 6 minutes

Model a sketchbook identity web and a short plan: “My sketchbook represents creativity and the way I communicate ideas visually.” Think aloud through beginning (where/when), middle (what happened), and end (why it matters). Present the model as an illustrative example.

5. Partner rehearsal | 8 minutes

Partners take turns telling a chosen or imagined story. Listeners ask: Why is it important? What happened? How did you feel? What does this tell us about the narrator? Each writer selects one useful detail to add.

6. Narrative writing | 19 minutes

Draft a short paragraph, generally 6-10 sentences, adjusted to language proficiency and individual supports. Include an object/place/experience, a clear sequence, at least one sensory detail, and a statement explaining significance.

Reserve the final minutes for a checklist review. Students may begin with bilingual notes and use an important home-language word with an explanation in English.

7. Exit reflection | 5 minutes

Complete: **One thing that helped me tell my story today was ____.** Invite volunteers to share a line or idea; do not require public disclosure.

From an idea to a story

Teacher-created mentor text

The Old Pot

Every Saturday morning, my grandmother used the same old pot to make soup. First, she set it on the stove and called me over to help. I listened to the spoon tap against the metal as we stirred. Later, the warm smell filled the kitchen, and my cousins arrived. I felt excited when we pulled our chairs around the table. The pot was scratched and faded, but to me it meant that our family had time to be together.

Original instructional example; the narrator is fictional. This expanded model demonstrates sequence, sensory detail, emotion, and significance.

Discussion prompts

What details help you imagine the scene? Which words show the order of events? What feeling does the narrator name? What does the final sentence suggest about what matters to the narrator?

Differentiation and sentence frames

Emerging: Provide illustrated vocabulary, an oral recording option, a bilingual web, and a three-part planner. Frames: “My important ____ is ____.” “First, ____.” “I feel ____ because ____.”

Transitioning: Offer optional sequencing and sensory word banks. Frames: “When ____ happened, I felt ____.” “____ is important to me because ____.”

Expanding: Ask for precise detail, varied sentences, and a reflective ending. Frames: “This experience shaped me because ____.” “Although ____ may seem ordinary, it represents ____ because ____.”

Translanguaging opportunities

Students may brainstorm in a home language, rehearse with a partner, consult bilingual dictionaries, or draft key ideas bilingually before deciding how to express them in English.

An important home-language expression can remain in the final narrative with context or an explanation, for example: “My grandmother called me *mi amor*, meaning my love.”

Accessibility

Provide a read-aloud and accessible digital text, enlarged print, speech-to-text or dictation, and extended processing time as needed. Offer a private conference instead of partner sharing. Follow individual IEP/504 supports.

Assess meaning and language

Formative assessment

Review identity webs and listen to partner rehearsal. Check whether students can identify a focus, sequence events, and explain why the memory or imagined event matters. Use a brief conference to support one next step before drafting.

Narrative checklist

Focus: Identifies a meaningful object, place, or experience.

Significance: Explains why it matters to the narrator.

Description: Includes at least one sensory detail.

Sequence: Uses words or structures that clarify event order.

Communication: Expresses ideas clearly with appropriate supports.

Record each criterion as evident, developing, or not yet evident. Keep notes on language support separately from the quality of ideas. Give a specific strength and one actionable revision suggestion.

Why I designed it this way

Students bring cultural, linguistic, and personal knowledge that can support literacy instruction. Choice makes those resources available without treating any student as a representative of a culture.

Separating idea generation, oral rehearsal, and written production reduces the demand of doing everything at once. Bilingual planning can help students develop ideas before deciding how to communicate them in English.

The mentor text makes the writing criteria visible. Students see how a small event becomes a narrative through sequence, sensory detail, and reflection.

Evidence and reflection after teaching

Collect an anonymized plan and draft to examine whether rehearsal supported detail and organization. Ask: Who communicated more through talk than writing? Which scaffold can be reduced next time? Did the choice of topic feel safe and meaningful?

These are planned assessment and reflection steps, not claims of observed student growth. Confirm permissions before publishing any student work.

Words, objects, and identity

Palabras, objetos e identidad

Teacher use: Display paired labels beside the same image in equally readable type. Read and model both labels when possible. Invite Spanish or bilingual planning, then support English practice toward the language objective. Offer other language supports as needed; Spanish is not every learner's home language.

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
identity / community / tradition	identidad / comunidad / tradición
narrative / sensory detail	narración / detalle sensorial
significance: why something matters	importancia: por qué algo es importante
first / later / when	primero / después / cuando
because / although	porque / aunque
Photo labels: book / headphones	Etiquetas: libro / audífonos
basketball / necklace	balón de baloncesto / collar
transit card / family photograph	tarjeta de transporte / fotografía familiar
sketchbook / cooking pot	cuaderno de dibujo / olla

Identity web / Mapa de identidad

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
ME: languages, neighborhood, hobbies, music, places, goals, experiences.	YO: idiomas, vecindario, pasatiempos, música, lugares, metas, experiencias.
Choose only what you want to share. You may invent a character or an event.	Elige solo lo que quieras compartir. Puedes inventar un personaje o un suceso.

Learning goal / Meta de aprendizaje

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
I can tell a short story with events in order, a sensory detail, and an explanation of why it matters.	Puedo contar una historia breve con sucesos en orden, un detalle sensorial y una explicación de por qué es importante.

The Old Pot / La olla vieja

Bilingual mentor text / Texto modelo bilingüe

Original fictional instructional text. Each row pairs the same part of the story in English and Spanish.

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Every Saturday morning, my grandmother used the same old pot to make soup.	Todos los sábados por la mañana, mi abuela usaba la misma olla vieja para preparar sopa.
First, she set it on the stove and called me over to help.	Primero, la ponía en la estufa y me llamaba para que le ayudara.
I listened to the spoon tap against the metal as we stirred.	Escuchaba el golpeteo de la cuchara contra el metal mientras revolvíamos la sopa.
Later, the warm smell filled the kitchen, and my cousins arrived.	Después, el aroma cálido llenaba la cocina y llegaban mis primos.
I felt excited when we pulled our chairs around the table.	Sentía mucha emoción cuando acercábamos las sillas a la mesa.
The pot was scratched and faded, but to me it meant that our family had time to be together.	La olla estaba rayada y descolorida, pero para mí significaba que nuestra familia tenía tiempo para estar junta.

Read and notice / Lee y observa

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Box important details. Underline emotions. Circle sequencing words.	Encierra en un recuadro los detalles importantes. Subraya las emociones. Rodea con un círculo las palabras que indican el orden.
Why does the object matter to the narrator?	¿Por qué es importante el objeto para quien narra la historia?
The writer shows that ____ matters because ____.	Quien escribe muestra que ____ es importante porque ____.

Plan and tell your story

Planea y cuenta tu historia

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Plan in English, Spanish, or both. Rehearse with a partner, then use the frames to support your English draft.	Planea en inglés, español o ambos idiomas. Practica con un compañero y luego usa los modelos de oración para apoyar tu borrador en inglés.
Beginning: Where and when? _____	Inicio: ¿Dónde y cuándo? _____
Middle: What happened? _____	Desarrollo: ¿Qué pasó? _____
End: Why does it matter? _____	Final: ¿Por qué es importante? _____

Sentence frames / Modelos de oración

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
_____ is important to me because _____.	_____ es importante para mí porque _____.
It reminds me of _____.	Me recuerda a _____.
When _____ happened, I felt _____.	Cuando pasó _____, me sentí _____.
Although _____ may seem ordinary, it represents _____ because _____.	Aunque _____ parezca común, representa _____ porque _____.

Check and reflect / Revisa y reflexiona

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Include a focus, a sensory detail, events in order, and why the story matters.	Incluye un tema central, un detalle sensorial, sucesos en orden y por qué la historia es importante.
One thing that helped me tell my story today was _____.	Algo que me ayudó a contar mi historia hoy fue _____.